

ODISEE UNIVERSITY OF APPLIED SCIENCES · BRUSSELS CAMPUS

Bridging the Gap

A Student Success Guide for Odisee Brussels

Three evidence-based tools to support every student at Odisee Brussels

Peer Mentoring · Early Alert · Self-Regulated Learning

Academic Year 2025–2026 · Inclusive Education & Student Success Project

**Every student belongs
here**

Support built into study

3 Tools

One integrated system
Mentoring · Alert · Learning

**High potential, targeted
support**

Right help, right time



Home

Welcome to Bridging the Gap — Odisee Brussels Student Success Programme

Welcome to This Guide

This guide was developed for Odisee University of Applied Sciences, Brussels Campus, as part of an evidence-based student success project. Whether you are a student, lecturer, peer mentor, programme coordinator, or member of leadership, this platform is designed for you.

Odisee Brussels is home to a genuinely diverse student community. Many students are the first in their family to attend university. Many are studying in a language that is not their mother tongue. Many carry financial pressures alongside their studies. These students are capable. They are motivated. And they deserve a university that meets them with the right support at the right moment.

This guide brings together three practical, evidence-based tools that do exactly that — built directly on institutional data, academic research, and the lived experience of students at Odisee Brussels.

Inspired by Previous Year

This project follows in the tradition of the GO! Scholengroep Brussel Inclusive Education Project (2025), which developed a digital platform and practical guidebook for inclusive education in Brussels schools. Like that project, Bridging the Gap translates complex evidence into tools that practitioners can use immediately, in their daily work, without additional burden.

How to Use This Guide

This guide is organised like a website — each section is a standalone page you can navigate directly to. Read it from cover to cover, or go straight to the section most relevant to you.

- Home — This page: purpose, context and how to navigate
- Understanding the Challenge — Why Odisee Brussels specifically needs this project
- Our Three Tools — What each tool is and who it is for
- Tool 1: Peer Mentoring Toolkit — Complete implementation guide for mentors and coordinators

- Tool 2: Early Alert Protocol — Complete protocol for teaching staff and coordinators
- Tool 3: Self-Regulated Learning Guide — Practical guide for students and staff
- Best Practices — Where these approaches have worked internationally
- Implementation Plan — How to bring all three tools to life at Odisee Brussels



Understanding the Challenge

Why Odisee Brussels — and why now

The Brussels Context

Brussels is not like other Belgian cities when it comes to higher education. As one of the most internationally connected capitals in Europe, it has long drawn migrants, refugees, and international families, making it one of the most ethnically and linguistically diverse cities on the continent. That diversity lands directly in higher education.

Over 25% of students in the Brussels-Capital Region are enrolled in a college or university — well above the Belgian national average of 15%. A growing share of those students come from migrant or low-income households. Statbel (2024) found that 18% of working-age adults in Brussels hold no diploma beyond primary school — the highest share of any Belgian region. This means many students arriving at Odisee Brussels are the first person in their family to ever walk into a university.

18%

adults with no diploma beyond primary school
Brussels — highest in Belgium
(Statbel, 2024)

9.8%

early school-leaving rate
Brussels — highest in Belgium
(European Commission, 2024)

23%

children in Brussels living in poverty
Eurochild (2024)

What Odisee Data Shows

An Odisee researcher from the Service for Innovation, Education and Quality Assurance confirmed that institutional data shows lower study efficiency specifically for students with a migrant background at the Brussels campus compared to other Odisee campuses. This is the gap this project sets out to address.



The Core Challenge

Students do not struggle at Odisee Brussels because they lack ability or motivation. Research from our literature review confirms that the biggest predictors of first-year academic struggle are: lack of structured study habits (Van Rooij et al., 2018); absence of belonging and peer connection (Gopalan & Brady, 2020); financial stress impairing working memory (Almarzouki, 2024); and being the first generation in the family at university (Barsegyan & Maas, 2024). None of these are fixed characteristics. All of them can be addressed through targeted, proactive support.

The Research Framework

This project is built on Tinto's Model of Student Departure (1987; 1993) — the most widely cited framework in retention research globally. Tinto's argument is that dropout is never a sudden decision. It is the slow result of a student becoming less and less connected to their studies, to the institution, and to the people around them. Hadjar, Haas, and Gewinner (2022) updated this model specifically to include immigration background and satisfaction with institutional support — making it directly applicable to Odisee Brussels.

Individual Factors

- First-generation student status
- Migrant or minority background
- Financial pressure and employment
- Language barriers in Dutch or French
- Lack of study skills at university level

Institutional Factors

- Absence of proactive early support
- Reactive rather than preventive systems
- Limited cultural adaptation of services
- Insufficient belonging-building structures
- Gap between policy intent and daily reality



Our Three Tools

One integrated system — three practical interventions

Why Three Tools, Not One

No single intervention solves the challenge of student dropout. The research is clear: reducing dropout requires coordinated institutional support — academic guidance, peer connection, financial assistance, and proactive monitoring working together, not in isolation (Apumayta et al., 2024). The three tools in this guide are designed to work as a system. Each one addresses a different dimension of student risk. Together, they create a safety net that reaches every student.

Tool 1 Peer Mentoring Toolkit

Connection, belonging and practical support — from someone who has been where you are

- Structured mentoring programme pairing first-year students with trained senior mentors
- Bi-weekly sessions with a clear agenda: goal-setting, check-in, reflection
- Five-weekly coordinator review ensures no student is lost between sessions
- Addresses social isolation, belonging deficit and first-generation disadvantage
- Evidence: Torres et al. (2025), Lapon et al. (2023), EEF +5 months

Tool 2 Early Alert Protocol

Act before the drift becomes a departure

- Five-step protocol: Signal · Observe · Reach Out · Connect · Follow Up
- Traffic light system: Green (watch), Amber (reach out), Red (act today)
- For teaching staff, peer mentors, and programme coordinators
- 14-day follow-up rule — no alert is ever left without a response
- Evidence: Villano et al. (2018), Jayaprakash et al. (2014), Plak et al. (2022)

Tool 3 Self-Regulated Learning Guide

Take ownership of your learning — three steps, proven by research, built for you

- Plan before you study · Monitor while you work · Evaluate after you finish
- Written for students — simple, direct, no extra sessions required
- Woven into every teaching session and every mentoring meeting
- Practical tools: 2-minute planner, 20-minute monitor pause, 3-minute reflection

- Evidence: EEF +8 months, Van Rooij et al. (2018) $r=.71$, Jansen et al. (2019)



Tool 1: Peer Mentoring Toolkit

You have been where they are standing right now.

What Is Peer Mentoring?

Peer mentoring pairs first-year students with trained senior students who have successfully navigated the same challenges. At Odisee Brussels, this means pairing students from migrant and low-income backgrounds with mentors who understand — from lived experience — what it feels like to arrive at university without a map.

This is not tutoring. Mentors do not teach course content. They offer something more valuable: connection, practical guidance, and the reassurance that what the mentee is experiencing is normal — and navigable.

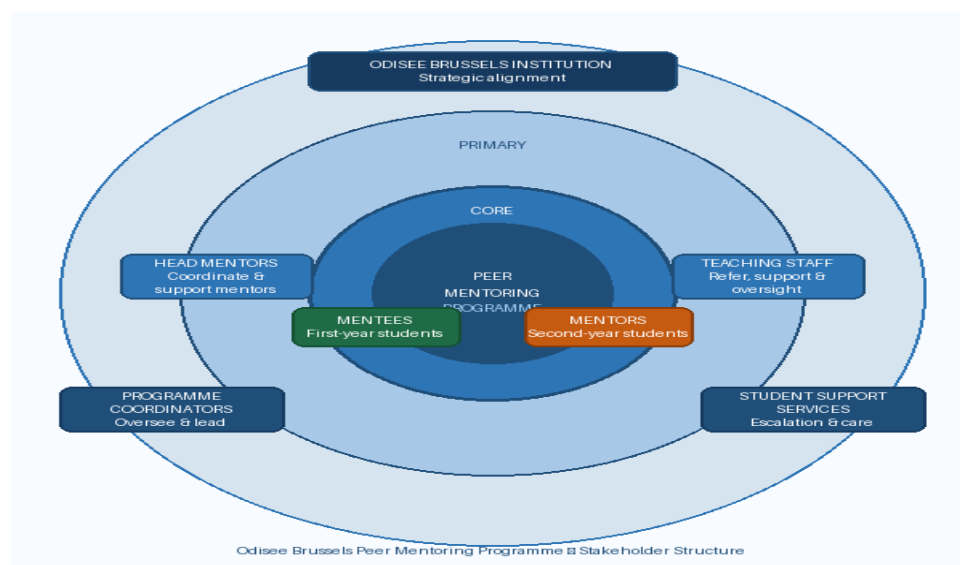


Figure 1: The Peer Mentoring Programme — stakeholders and structure at Odisee Brussels.

Why Peer Mentoring Works — The Evidence

The evidence for peer mentoring in diverse higher education settings is strong and consistent. Torres et al. (2025) found that structured peer mentoring significantly improved academic performance and sense of belonging among first-generation university students. Lapon et al. (2023) confirmed that mentoring specifically supports students from migrant backgrounds by reducing social isolation and strengthening institutional connection. The EEF Teaching and Learning Toolkit estimates peer tutoring and mentoring adds an average of five additional months of progress.

Tinto (1987; 1993) placed peer connection at the heart of his departure model: students who form meaningful relationships with peers and staff are significantly more likely to persist. Gopalan and Brady (2020) confirmed that sense of belonging independently predicts retention across all student demographics.

How the Programme Works

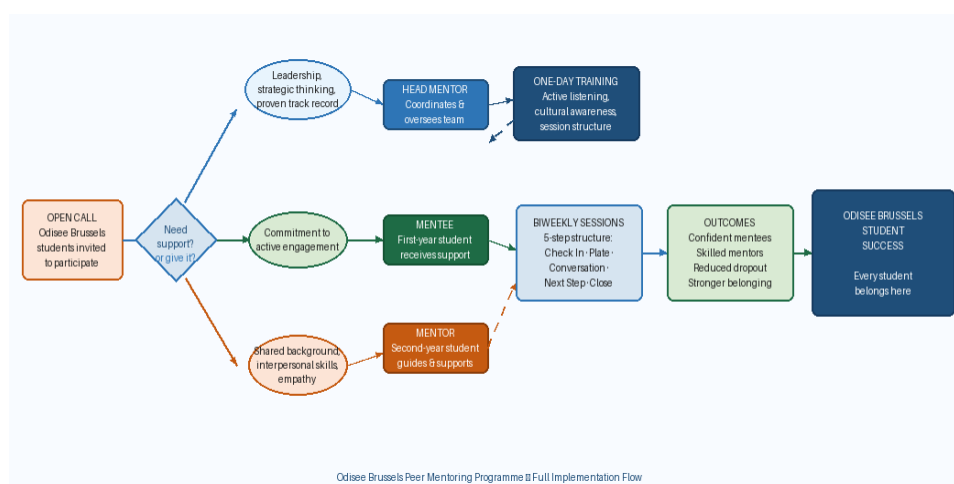


Figure 2: The Peer Mentoring Programme flow — from matching to review.

Programme Element	Details
Session frequency	Bi-weekly meetings throughout the academic year (21 weeks)
Session structure	Opening goal (5 min) · Check-in (10 min) · Main topic (30 min) · Reflection (5 min)
Coordinator review	Every 5 weeks — head mentor reviews all check-in notes, flags concerns
Mentor training	One full-day training before the year begins. Refresher session at Week 11.
Connection to Tool 2	Mentor concern notes feed directly into the Early Alert Protocol

What Mentors Gain

Mentoring is not a one-way exchange. Mentors at Odisee Brussels receive a formal certificate of completion, build communication and leadership skills recognised by employers, develop intercultural competence in one of Europe's most diverse cities, and gain documented experience of contributing to institutional inclusion goals. This is a genuine professional development opportunity.

SMART Criteria

Criterion	How Peer Mentoring Meets It
Specific	Bi-weekly structured sessions with defined agenda, 5-weekly coordinator review, formal matching process
Measurable	Check-in notes per session, 5-weekly review records, end-of-year student reflection surveys
Achievable	Uses existing senior students, no new budget beyond coordinator time and mentor training
Relevant	Directly addresses social isolation, belonging deficit and first-generation disadvantage at Brussels campus
Time-Bound	Matching complete Week 1; active programme Weeks 2-21; end-of-year review Weeks 19-21

Strengths Peer-to-peer trust — more accessible than staff support Lived experience addresses cultural and language barriers Connects all three tools as the primary student relationship Low cost — uses existing student community	Challenges to Manage Mentor wellbeing must be monitored and supported Quality depends on consistent coordinator oversight Matching process requires care and cultural sensitivity Some students may initially resist the relationship
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Tool 2: Early Alert Protocol

Act before the drift becomes a departure.

What Is the Early Alert Protocol?

The Early Alert Protocol is a structured, proactive system that enables teaching staff and programme coordinators to identify students who are beginning to show signs of academic risk — and to reach out to them with care and support before the situation becomes unrecoverable. It is not surveillance. It is coordinated care.

Students do not suddenly decide to quit university. They drift away gradually — missing one deadline, then another, becoming quieter, then absent, until one day they are gone. By the time traditional grading reveals a problem, it is often too late. The protocol interrupts that drift at the earliest possible moment.

Warning Signs — The Traffic Light System



Figure 3: Warning signs at three levels. Green = watch. Amber = reach out this week. Red = act today.

The Five-Step Protocol

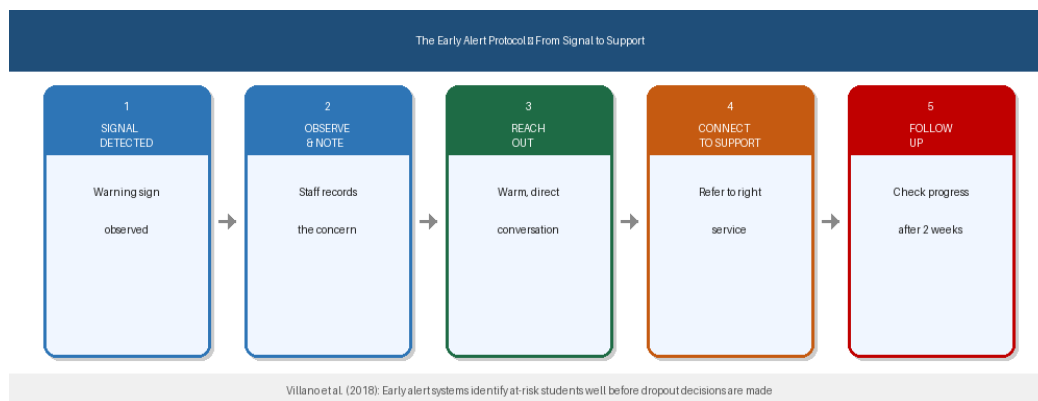


Figure 4: The Early Alert Protocol — five steps from signal to support. Villano et al. (2018).

Step	Action	Who	Timeline
1 — Signal	Warning sign observed using traffic light framework	Any staff member or mentor	Immediately
2 — Record	Concern Note completed (5 minutes)	Person who observed	Same day
3 — Reach Out	Warm, direct message or conversation	Lecturer or mentor	Within 3 days
4 — Connect	Refer to appropriate support service	Programme coordinator	Within 1 week
5 — Follow Up	Check progress — logged in Concern Note	Person who initiated	Within 14 days

Where It Has Worked

University	Country	Key Result
Purdue University — Course Signals	USA	55% of high-risk students improved after one warm message; significantly higher retention over 3 years (Jayaprakash et al., 2014)
Marist College — OAAI	USA	Proven effective across different institution types; warm language outperforms alarmist language every time
Dutch University Field Experiment	Netherlands	Proactive outreach made counselling more effective; strongest effect for students who would not seek help themselves (Plak et al., 2022)
Kingston University	London, UK	3,000+ students identified per year; text-based outreach improved progression and widening participation outcomes

SMART Criteria

Criterion	How the Early Alert Protocol Meets It
Specific	Five-step protocol, traffic light system, Concern Note template, referral pathway, 14-day follow-up rule
Measurable	Number of alerts raised; proportion with 14-day follow-up; re-engagement rate; coordinator review records
Achievable	No new technology, no new budget — uses existing staff, relationships and communication channels
Relevant	Directly addresses the study efficiency gap and first-year dropout risk at Odisee Brussels
Time-Bound	Active monitoring Weeks 1-18; mid-year review Week 10; end-of-year review Weeks 19-21

Strengths Proactive — acts before dropout, not after Low cost — uses existing relationships Connects mentor observations to coordinator action 14-day rule prevents students falling through	Threats to Manage Alert fatigue if too many signals raised — traffic light prevents this Stigma risk — warm language is non-negotiable Only works if staff follow through — coordinator review is essential
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Tool 3: Self-Regulated Learning Guide

Take ownership of your learning — three steps, proven by research, built for you.

What Is Self-Regulated Learning?

Self-regulated learning is the ability to plan your studying, check whether you are understanding things as you go, and reflect on what worked afterwards. The Education Endowment Foundation defines it as: students' ability to monitor, direct and review their own learning — by setting goals, and monitoring and evaluating their academic progress (EEF, 2025).

For many students at Odisee Brussels — especially those who are first-generation, studying in a second language, or balancing work and financial pressure — these habits have never been explicitly taught. The SRL Guide addresses that gap directly.



Figure 5: What, Why, How, When and Where of Self-Regulated Learning at Odisee Brussels.

The Three Steps



Figure 6: Plan · Monitor · Evaluate — the three steps of self-regulated learning. EEF Recommendation 2 (2025).

Step	When	What You Do	Evidence
1 — PLAN	Before every session	Set a goal, choose your approach, break the task into steps	Fokkens-Bruinsma et al. (2021): goal-setting is the strongest predictor of first-year success
2 — MONITOR	During — every 20 min	Am I understanding this? Am I on track? Should I adjust?	Van Rooij et al. (2018): $r=.71$ between SRL and academic adjustment
3 — EVALUATE	After every session	What worked? What was hard? What will I do differently?	Jansen et al. (2019): 126 studies — reflection consistently improves grades and habits

The Three Student Tools

Three practical tools — five minutes total — for use before, during and after every study session.

Tool	When	Time Needed
Tool A — The 2-Minute Planner: What is my goal? How will I study? How long do I have?	Before every session	2 minutes
Tool B — The 20-Minute Monitor Pause: Am I understanding this — or just reading the words?	During — every 20 minutes	1 minute
Tool C — The 3-Minute Reflection: What went well? What was hard? What will I do differently?	After every session	3 minutes

EEF Recommendations Built In

EEF Recommendation (2025)	How It Is Applied in This Guide
Rec. 1: Teachers acquire professional understanding of SRL	Teaching staff briefed in induction week on all three steps
Rec. 2: Explicitly teach plan, monitor, evaluate	Students receive this guide in Week 1. All three steps are introduced in a teaching session.
Rec. 3: Model thinking out loud	Lecturers verbalise their own thinking in every session — showing what self-regulation looks like
Rec. 4: Set appropriate challenge	Peer mentor adjusts support level to each student's stage of habit formation
Rec. 6: Teach independent learning management	Tools A, B and C give students practical independence without requiring ongoing instruction

Strengths

No extra sessions — woven into what already exists
Addresses the specific study skill gap at Brussels campus
Gives students autonomy and confidence
Connects directly to mentor check-ins (Tool 1)

Challenges to Manage

Habit formation takes time — staff must reinforce consistently
Students may initially resist reflection step
Language barriers may affect written reflection quality



Best Practices

International evidence — what works and where

Peer Mentoring — International Evidence

Institution / Study	Country	What Happened	Outcome
Torres et al. (2025)	International	Structured peer mentoring for first-generation students	Significantly improved academic performance and belonging
Lapon et al. (2023)	Belgium / Netherlands	Mentoring for migrant-background students in higher education	Reduced social isolation, strengthened institutional connection
Plaskett et al. (2018)	USA	Peer mentoring in diverse university settings	First-generation students showed stronger persistence and GPA gains
Flores et al. (2018)	USA	Near-peer mentoring for minority-background students	Higher retention and stronger academic identity across two years

Early Alert — International Evidence

Institution / Study	Country	What Happened	Outcome
Purdue University — Course Signals (Jayaprakash et al., 2014)	USA	Personalised alerts to at-risk students	55% of high-risk moved to lower risk; significantly higher 3-year retention
Marist College — OAAI (Jayaprakash et al., 2014)	USA	Open-source alert system across multiple institution types	Proven portable; warm language consistently outperforms alarmist language
Dutch University (Plak et al., 2022)	Netherlands	Early warning field experiment	Proactive outreach most effective for students who would not seek help themselves

Kingston University (SEAtS, 2024)	London, UK	Unified attendance and engagement monitoring	3,000+ students identified per year; improved progression and widening participation
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Self-Regulated Learning — International Evidence

Study	Finding
EEF Teaching & Learning Toolkit (2025)	Metacognition and self-regulation: +8 months additional progress — highest-impact lowest-cost strategy
Van Rooij et al. (2018)	Correlation of .71 between SRL and academic adjustment — the strongest predictor in the entire model
Jansen et al. (2019)	Meta-analysis of 126 higher education studies: teaching SRL consistently improves both grades and study habits
Fokkens-Bruinsma et al. (2021)	Time management and autonomous motivation are the two strongest predictors of first-year academic success
Koh et al. (2022)	3,316 first-generation students: self-regulation was the bridge between believing in success and staying enrolled



Implementation Plan

How to bring all three tools to life at Odisee Brussels

The Strategic Approach

The three tools in this guide are not independent projects. They are a coordinated system. Tool 1 (Peer Mentoring) builds the relationship. Tool 2 (Early Alert) catches when that relationship is not enough. Tool 3 (SRL) gives students the skills to sustain themselves. The implementation plan below ensures all three run in alignment throughout the academic year.

Academic Year Timeline

Phase	Timing	Key Actions	Tools Active
Preparation	Before Year Begins	Brief all staff on tools 1, 2, 3. Train mentors. Confirm referral pathways. Set up check-in note system.	All three
Launch	Induction Week	Introduce tools to students. Match mentors to mentees. Deliver SRL Guide session. Brief students on Early Alert approach.	Tools 1 + 3
Active Phase 1	Weeks 1-5	Bi-weekly mentoring sessions begin. Teaching staff observe for green/amber signals. SRL habits introduced in sessions.	All three
First Review	Week 5	Head mentor reviews all check-in notes. Flag any amber signals to coordinator. SRL habits check.	Tools 1 + 2
Active Phase 2	Weeks 6-10	Continue mentoring. Early alert monitoring active. Lecturers modelling SRL in every session.	All three
Mid-Year Review	Week 10-11	Coordinator reviews all open concern notes. Unresolved red alerts escalated. Protocol quality review.	Tools 2 + 3
Active Phase 3	Weeks 11-18	Continue all three tools. Mentor relationships deepening. SRL habits embedding.	All three
Close	Weeks 19-21	Student reflections gathered. All concern notes reviewed. Evidence documented for next year.	All three

Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities Across All Three Tools
Students	Use the SRL guide tools A, B, C. Engage with their peer mentor. Respond to any outreach warmly and honestly.
Peer Mentors	Run bi-weekly sessions. Complete check-in notes. Flag concerns to head mentor. Model and reinforce SRL habits.
Head Mentor	Collect and review check-in notes every 5 weeks. Escalate amber/red to coordinator within 48 hours.
Teaching Staff	Embed SRL in every session (before, during, after). Observe for warning signs. Raise concern notes at amber/red level.
Programme Coordinator	Oversee all three tools. Receive escalations. Ensure 14-day follow-up on every alert. Lead all reviews.
Student Support Service	Receive referrals. Provide counselling, financial, language and crisis support. Feed outcomes back to coordinator.

SMART Project Summary

SMART Criterion	How This Project Meets It
Specific	Three defined tools with clear protocols, roles, timelines and forms — all described in detail in this guide
Measurable	Check-in notes, concern note logs, alert follow-up rates, student reflection surveys, end-of-year review data
Achievable	No new budget, no new technology, no extra sessions — embedded in existing teaching, mentoring and coordination
Relevant	Directly addresses the study efficiency gap for migrant-background and first-generation students at Odisee Brussels
Time-Bound	Full academic year 2025-2026; formal reviews at Weeks 5, 10 and 19-21; outcomes documented for future years

A Final Note

Bridging the Gap is not a programme that asks students to change to fit the institution. It is a commitment from Odisee Brussels to meet students where they are — with connection, with care, and with the practical skills they need to succeed. Every student who arrives at Odisee Brussels deserves to stay, progress, and belong. These three tools make that possible.

